

Santa Maria del Fiore

Although this Florentine cathedral is predominantly Gothic in design, it is seen as a testament to the remarkable achievements of the Renaissance. Surmounted by Brunelleschi's magnificent ribbed dome, the patterned red, green and white marble exterior is the consequence of the city's efforts to eclipse its great rivals, particularly Siena and Pisa. In 1294, the city council commissioned architect Arnolfo di Cambio (1240–1310) 'to make a design ... in a style of magnificence which neither the industry, not the power of man can surpass'. Arnolfo designed the huge, vaulted basilica with an octagonal crossing, but it required a dome so enormous that it was beyond the scope of any contemporary architect. The cathedral's construction continued for over 100 years with various additions and adjustments, but the failure to build the dome remained a source of embarrassment for the Florentines. Then Brunelleschi won a competition and began building his 45-metre (148-ft) pointed dome c.1420, without scaffolding. It remains the largest masonry dome ever built.

